

He was the first person I dated who was vocally judgmental of my financial connection to my parents. My Bank of America account was linked to theirs and they periodically used my account as if it was one of their own, funneling money in and out. At 24, I didn't see anything wrong with that. My money was their money and their money was my money. When I revealed this information to my boyfriend, he expressed grave concern.

"You need to get your own bank account that they can't access," he said. (My friend Lauren also chastised me when I told her this story. She's had her own bank account since she was 15.)

My parents were concerned that this guy's ultimate plan was to take me away from them and "money independence" was his excuse. They fought back against my opening my own bank account, which might not have occurred to me to do without this man's influence, but also now seemed obviously overdue. I felt guilty about getting my own account, but I did it.

The problem was this older dude, and the ones around me who loved to give me advice on how to be an adult, were not financially independent themselves. I was surrounded by people, mostly male comedians, stuck in arrested development. It seemed normal that well into your 30s, you'd be out partying all night with nothing in your savings account. I didn't understand how these people made money. How could one of the 35-year-old guys I drank with afford to live in a condo downtown by himself but never have a job to speak of?

My then-boyfriend was deep in credit card debt, a sentence I barely understood. I spent a lot of time googling "what it means to marry someone with debt." The results were terrifying. Many op-eds advised against it. My mom, a divorce attorney, advised against it. Money, she warned, is the number one reason for divorce.

"You start off the marriage behind the eight ball," she said. "You can't build a life. How do you save for a house? How do you travel?" She also worried about my marrying someone in credit card debt because "it shows irresponsibility and not being realistic about your lifestyle." (I don't know if I agree with this, but she's a concerned mom.)

Ed, a 50-year-old retired software engineer from Hong Kong, told me in a phone interview that he makes good money. When he married his wife, she had